

CAVALRY ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

As firearms became more common, armour was made thicker, and its less important features were abandoned to reduce its weight. At the beginning of the 17th century, cavalry – armed with wheellock pistols and swords – still wore knee-length armour. New tactics such as the caracole, which involved successive ranks of riders discharging their pistols before riding to the rear to reload, were developed in order to defeat pikemen. By the middle of the century, most cavalry, now called *harquebusiers* due to the weapons they carried, wore only a heavy cuirass and an open helmet over a buff coat.



▲ FLEMISH CUIRASSIER'S HELMET

Date c.1600

Origin Holland

Material Iron, leather

Most helmets of this period were made in two halves that were joined along the comb. The bevor covering the chin and the peak pivoted at the same point. Attached to the peak was an almost flat plate covering the face; the plate was pierced for vision and breathing.



▲ FLINTLOCK PISTOL

Date c.1650

Origin England

Weight 1.78kg (4lb)

Barrel 15.3cm (6in)

Calibre 15mm

This all-steel pistol is interesting as its mechanism is exposed on the outside of the stock. A spring-loaded tumbler that runs through the stock governs the striking action of the cock when the trigger is pulled.

► FIELD ARMOUR

Date c.1630

Origin Germany

Material Iron, leather

At the beginning of the 17th century, heavy cavalry cuirassiers wore three-quarter-length armours such as this, with the lower legs protected by boots. The lance was mostly abandoned in favour of a sword and a pair of pistols carried in holsters at the saddle.

